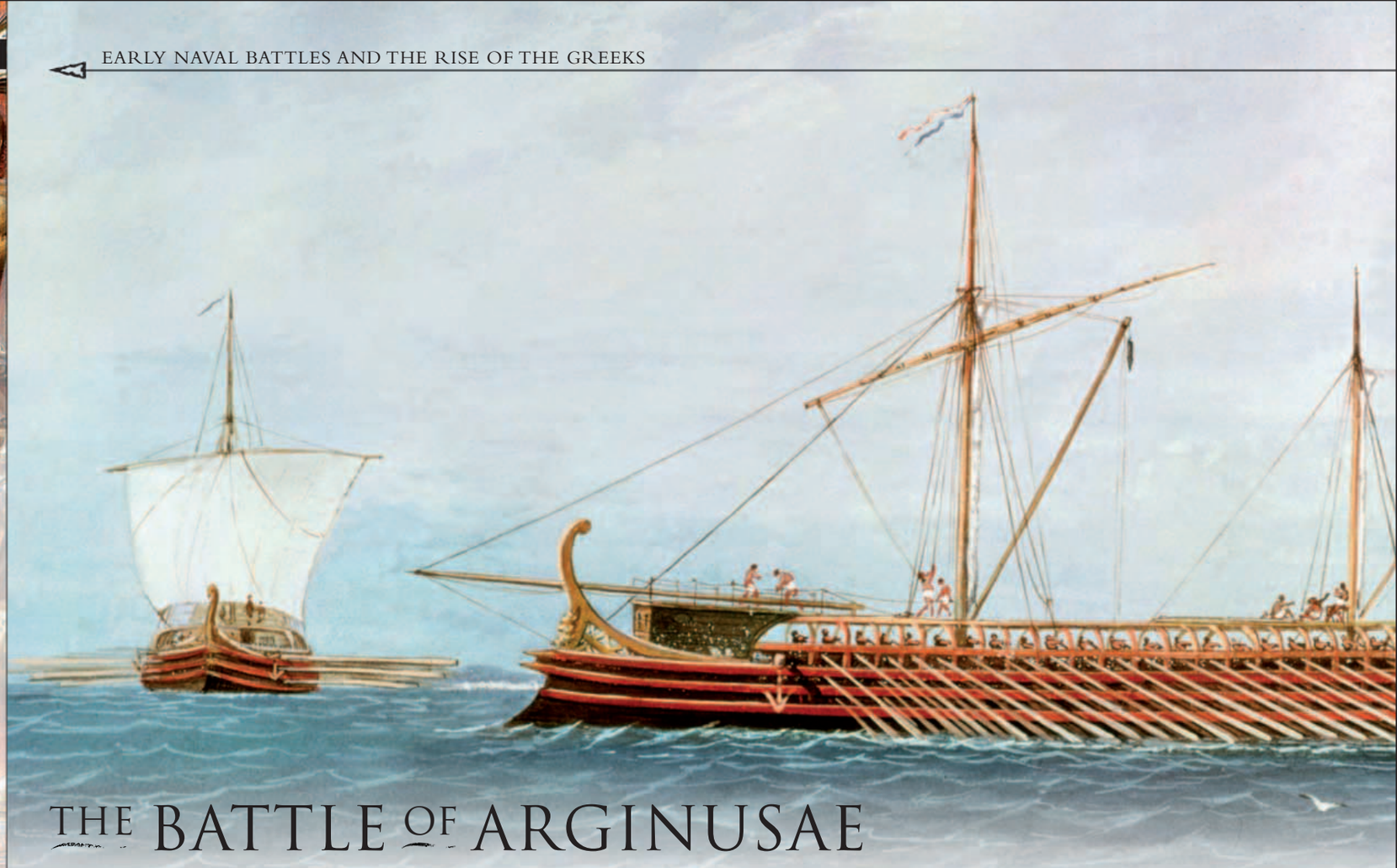
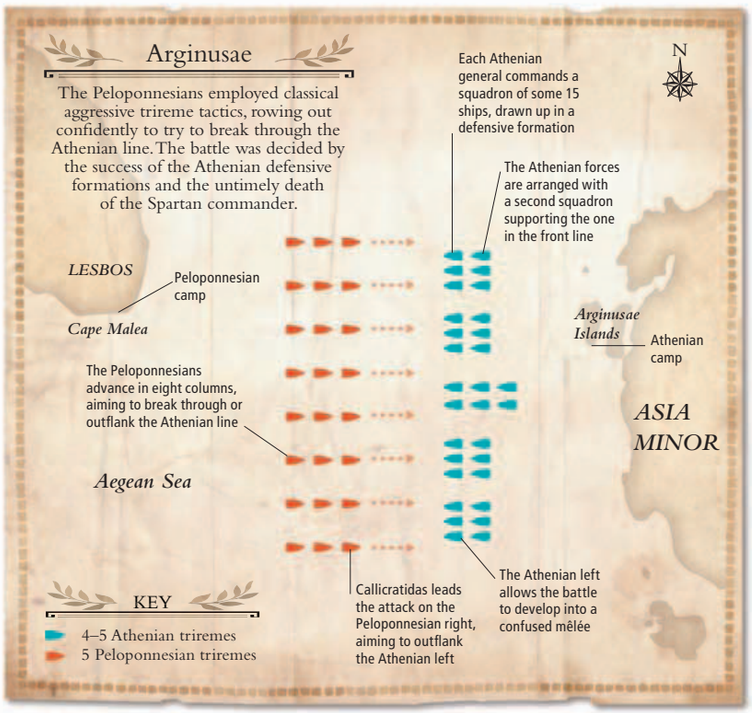


THE BATTLE OF ARGINUSAE

In 406 BCE Sparta and its Peloponnesian allies assembled a large fleet of triremes. Under the command of the Spartan navarch Callicratidas, it caught up with the Athenian general Conon near Mytilene on the island of Lesbos, and sank 30 of his ships. When Callicratidas blockaded the Athenians in Mytilene harbour, Conon sent a message to Athens detailing his plight. The Athenians reacted by building a new fleet—paid for by melting down the gold statue of Nike—and recruiting slaves and foreigners in the city to serve as oarsmen, since the supply of experienced free rowers was exhausted.



Placed under the command of eight generals, this inexperienced fleet was sent to the relief of Mytilene. Leaving 50 of his ships to maintain the blockade, Callicratidas sailed to meet the Athenians, making camp at Cape Malea, from where he could observe his enemies beached on the Arginusae Islands an hour's rowing away. The Spartan navarch planned a surprise night attack but this was abandoned because of a squall. Instead, it was at dawn that Callicratidas, positioned in the place of honor on the right wing, led his ships across the channel toward the enemy camp.

The Athenians scrambled to launch their ships, each general leading his own squadron. The Peloponnesians approached with groups of galleys in line ahead, intending to break though gaps in the Athenian line or outflank it, the classic maneuvers for victory in trireme contests. The inexperienced Athenian crews could not match Callicratidas for speed or nimbleness, so they adopted a novel defensive formation, each Athenian general organizing his triremes into a compact group several lines deep.

The fighting was prolonged, but at some point Callicratidas's galley was rammed and he disappeared into the sea. The Spartan right then collapsed and fled, leaving the left to sustain the full weight of the Athenian onslaught before it also broke. Athens had a naval victory to celebrate—in fact, its last—and the grateful city granted citizenship



Spartan ship
Sparta's power depended on its soldiers rather than its sailors. This ivory relief of a warship shows Spartan hoplites on its deck.

> AS HIS VESSEL DASHED HER BEAK INTO HER ANTAGONIST, HE WAS HURLED OFF INTO THE SEA AND DISAPPEARED.
>
> **XENOPHON**, DESCRIBING THE DEATH OF SPARTAN COMMANDER CALLICRATIDAS AT ARGINUSAE